



# The December 2026 rules

The rules any proposed CEA link for the December 2026 timetable is measured against, with today's link beside each one

Prepared 29 September 2026 · the rules and every figure below are read from the same code that writes the proposal sheets, not typed

## HARD LIMITS

A design must meet these or it cannot be run.  
Three of them.

## DECEMBER 2026 RULES

The staffing the station has asked for. Eleven of them, each met or not. Weigh them against each other.

## FATIGUE FACTORS

Patterns that tend to tire people. Advisory only: "present" means worth a look, never a breach.

## The basics every rule assumes

**Opening hours.** The station opens at 06:20 (07:15 on a Sunday) and closes at 23:55 (23:25 on a Sunday). **No duty runs past 23:25 on a Sunday** — agreed practice, settled 28 Sep 2026 — although 5 Sunday trains move later, the last at 23:54.

**Cover week.** A line with no fixed shifts: four duties in the week, placed by the roster clerk to cover leave and sickness.

**The floor.** Everyone on duty except the four ticket-office staff, who are there for the office's opening hours, not the trains. One of each ticket-office pair helps on the floor at the quiet ends: the morning one until 08:00 (09:00 on a Sunday), the evening one from 19:30; on a Sunday evening they split their time, counted as half a person.

**The link.** 24 lines worked in turn, one week each, Sunday to Saturday; a person on the last line moves to line 1.

**Early and late.** A shift starting before 11:00 is an early; from 11:00 it is a late.

**Today's link.** The 20-line link worked now. It is the yardstick, not the target: it meets 4 of the 11 December rules.

## Hard limits **MUST BE MET**

| LIMIT                                       | WHAT IT MEANS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | TODAY'S LINK              |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>At least 12 hours between duties</b>     | From the end of one duty to the start of the next, anywhere in the rotation — Saturday into Sunday, and the last line into line 1, included.                                                                                                                      | ✓ <b>shortest 12h 30m</b> |
| <b>No more than 13 days worked in a row</b> | Chiltern's limit, taken at its worst case: a cover week's four duties placed as badly as they can be. The written source of the 13-day limit is still to be confirmed.                                                                                            | ✓ <b>longest 9 days</b>   |
| <b>The contracted week, exactly</b>         | 35 hours a week on average, Monday to Saturday, across all 24 lines; a cover week counts as a contracted week. Sunday duties are paid on top as rest-day working, as they are today. Individual weeks may be longer or shorter; only the average is the contract. | ✓ <b>exactly 35h</b>      |

## The December 2026 rules **MET OR NOT**

Every number is a **minimum**: too few is the problem, never too many. The staffing levels, the 24-person link and the Sunday cover have all been confirmed verbally.

| RULE                                                                          | WHAT IT ASKS, EXACTLY                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | TODAY'S LINK                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| <b>At least four on at the open, every day</b>                                | Four people on duty from the moment the station opens: 06:20, or 07:15 on a Sunday.                                                                                                                                                   | × 4 · 4 · 3                               |
| <b>At least three through to the close, every day</b>                         | Three people still on duty until the station closes: 23:55, or 23:25 on a Sunday.                                                                                                                                                     | × 2 · 2 · 3                               |
| <b>At least five still on duty at 22:00, every day</b>                        | Five people still on duty at 22:00, every day, Sunday included. Only people working <i>after</i> 22:00 count; someone finishing at 22:00 does not (both settled 28 Sep 2026).                                                         | × 4 · 2 · 3                               |
| <b>Fourteen on a Saturday, ten on a Sunday</b>                                | Fourteen people working on a Saturday and ten on a Sunday, counted as duties rostered that day.                                                                                                                                       | × 10 · 8                                  |
| <b>Four cover weeks, evenly spread</b>                                        | Four cover weeks in the 24 lines, spaced evenly — every six lines, e.g. lines 1, 7, 13 and 19.                                                                                                                                        | × lines 1, 7, 12, 17                      |
| <b>The ticket office: two early and two late, identical shifts, every day</b> | Two identical early and two identical late shifts for the ticket office: Mon–Fri 06:20–14:20 and 14:00–22:30; Sat 06:20–14:50 and 14:30–22:00; Sun two starting 07:15 and two finishing 22:30.                                        | × Mon–Fri yes · Sat yes · Sun no          |
| <b>Every weekday closer starts at 15:45</b>                                   | Every Monday-to-Friday shift that works to the 23:55 close starts at 15:45.                                                                                                                                                           | × closers start at 15:15                  |
| <b>At least two on the floor at every moment</b>                              | At least two people on the station floor at every moment the station is open, checked every five minutes. Ticket-office staff count only while the second of a pair helps on the floor at the quiet ends, and only as a whole person. | ✓ <b>fewest 2 · 2 · 2</b>                 |
| <b>Handovers: 15 minutes to each closer, 20 in the ticket office</b>          | Each closer overlaps someone already on duty by 15 minutes; the two ticket-office shifts overlap by 20. On a Sunday each opener also stays until 15 minutes after the last closer arrives.                                            | ✓ <b>floor met · ticket office 20 min</b> |
| <b>Sunday duties between 8h and 9h</b>                                        | Every Sunday duty is between 8 and 9 hours long.                                                                                                                                                                                      | ✓ <b>8h 00m–8h 55m</b>                    |
| <b>No more shift times than today</b>                                         | No more different shift times in the week than today's link has (18).                                                                                                                                                                 | ✓ <b>18</b>                               |

Today's figures read Mon–Fri · Saturday · Sunday; a range means the weekdays differ.  
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# Fatigue factors, preferences, and what is still open

The advisory list, what is for staff to say rather than the rules, and the questions not yet settled

## Fatigue factors ADVISORY

25 roster patterns that tend to tire people: 21 from the Office of Rail and Road's good-practice guidance, *Fatigue Factors* (page 3, December 2021), and 4 extra checks from the rail industry's fatigue guidance (MRSF). The ORR says they are guidance, not limits. So a factor present is a question to discuss, never a pass or a fail, and a design showing none is not thereby approved.

| CODE        | FACTOR                                                                                 | KIND                     | TODAY'S LINK   |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|----------------|
| <b>FF2</b>  | Early shift starting 05:00–07:00                                                       | Time of day              | Every link     |
| <b>FF3</b>  | Very early shift starting before 05:00                                                 | Time of day              | Clear          |
| <b>FF5</b>  | Day shift over 12h                                                                     | Duty length              | Clear          |
| <b>FF7</b>  | Early shift over 10h                                                                   | Duty length              | Clear          |
| <b>FF8b</b> | Fewer than 2 days rest after a block of early starts                                   | Recovery time            | Present (3)    |
| <b>FF11</b> | More than 13 consecutive shifts without a 48h break                                    | Recovery time            | Clear          |
| <b>FF10</b> | More than 4 consecutive 12h day shifts                                                 | Cumulative               | Clear          |
| <b>FF15</b> | More than 4 consecutive early shifts in a rotating pattern                             | Cumulative               | Present (6)    |
| <b>MRSF</b> | More than 12 consecutive day shifts                                                    | Cumulative               | Clear          |
| <b>MRSF</b> | More than 55 hours worked in any 7-day period                                          | Cumulative               | Present (60.8) |
| <b>MRSF</b> | More than 7 consecutive 8h shifts                                                      | Cumulative               | Present (9)    |
| <b>FF17</b> | Backward rotating pattern                                                              | Circadian                | Clear          |
| <b>FF18</b> | Rotating pattern of about a week                                                       | Circadian                | Every link     |
| <b>FF19</b> | Successive start times varying by more than 2 hours <span>definition to confirm</span> | Circadian                | Present (6)    |
| <b>FF13</b> | Less than 12h rest in any 24h                                                          | Intervals between duties | Clear          |

**Not applicable.** 10 more factors apply to no rotation here: 8 about night shifts (FF1, FF6, FF8, FF9, FF12, FF14, FF16 and FF20), because CEAs do not work nights; FF4, because no shift starts before 05:00; and the MRSF permanent-pattern check, because the link rotates (FF15 is its rotating equivalent). **"Every link"** marks a standing factor — one that comes with the station's hours or with any weekly link, not with a design's choices: FF2 because the station opens at 06:20, and FF18 because a weekly link changes shift type about once a week (the ORR prefers two-day or three-week rotation, *Managing rail staff fatigue* 7.68). **Standing factors are recorded on every sheet for information and are not counted** in any design's fatigue findings, since no weekly design can remove them. The **early** in FF2 and FF15 is the ORR's — a start from 05:00 to 07:00 — not the 11:00 used everywhere else. The last column is today's link.

## Preferences FOR STAFF TO SAY, NOT THE APP

- **Days in a row.** The Links designer aims for six or fewer, well inside the 13-day limit.
- **Full weekends off** — a Saturday off followed by a Sunday off at the start of the next line. Today's link gives 4 in 20.
- **Weeks on one shift time** — the same clock time Monday to Friday, all earlies or all lates. A week that mixes the two is what people mean by "all over the place".
- **Familiar shift times** — how many of a design's times somebody already works today. A rough guide to what there is to learn, not to what staff will accept.
- **Following the trains** — how closely the floor's staffing follows the December 2026 timetable, hour by hour. A guide, and one way of measuring it among several.

## Still to settle

1. **The source of the 13-day limit.** Somebody confirms where it is written down.
2. **One fatigue definition to confirm.** FF19 is counted on a reading an assessing manager should confirm: FF19 treats a rest day as time to adjust, where the ORR's wording ("consecutive duties") would count across rest days — and on that reading every link has it.

**Changing a rule.** Every proposal sheet is checked against this set by the same code. Change a rule and every sheet and this page are re-rendered together, so no sheet is ever judged against an older version of it.